

As was indicated earlier, functional specialists are accustomed to measuring their efficiency by looking at the proportion of time they are busy doing their work. A programmer expects to be coding all day long, for example. That is why many traditional work environments frustrate these experts: the constant interruption of meetings, cross-functional handoffs, and explanations for endless numbers of bosses all act as a drag on efficiency. However, the individual efficiency of these specialists is not the goal in a Lean Startup. Instead, we want to force teams to work cross-functionally to achieve validated learning. Many of the techniques for doing this—actionable metrics, continuous deployment, and the overall Build-Measure-Learn feedback loop—necessarily cause teams to suboptimize for their individual functions. It does not matter how fast we can build. It does not matter how fast we can measure. What matters is how fast we can get through the entire loop.

In my years teaching this system, I have noticed this pattern every time: switching to validated learning feels worse before it feels better. That's the case because the problems caused by the old system tend to be intangible, whereas the problems of the new system are all too tangible. Having the benefit of theory is the antidote to these challenges. If it is known that this loss of productivity is an inevitable part of the transition, it can be managed actively. Expectations can be set up front. In my consulting practice, for example, I have learned to raise these issues from day one; otherwise, they are liable to derail the whole effort once it is under way. As the change progresses, we can use the root cause analysis and fast response techniques to figure out which problems need prevention. Ultimately, the Lean Startup is a framework, not a blueprint of steps to follow. It is designed to be adapted to the conditions of each specific company. Rather than copy what others have done, techniques such as the Five Whys allow you to build something that is perfectly suited to your company.

The best way to achieve mastery of and explore these ideas is to embed oneself in a community of practice. There is a thriving community of Lean Startup meetups around the world as well as